



The Square We Keep

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Today we honor a place so ordinary that most of us walk across it without looking down. The public square. The plaza, the town green, the common ground at the center of a city, where a person can stand without buying anything and still belong.

2 Consider how long we have kept it. In Athens the agora held the assembly and the debate and the market and the daily business of being a citizen from at least the sixth century before the common era; in Rome the Forum gathered the law, the worship, and the argument of the republic into one open ground; in the towns of medieval Europe the central square took in the market, the governance, the ceremony, and the crowd. Different centuries, the same instinct. People built an empty middle on purpose and called it the most important room in the city, though it had no roof.

3 The square asked nothing of you. It did not check your purse at the edge. A citizen of an old town could enter the plaza with empty hands and full standing, because the right to be there came with belonging and not with buying. This is the quiet thing the square was built to do, and it is the thing we are losing. It is to meet the stranger you would otherwise never meet; it is to stand beside the person whose politics you do not share; it is to be counted among people you did not choose.

4 There is a detail at the Athenian agora that I keep returning to. The site still holds the remains of the Stoa, the covered walkways that let citizens gather and argue when the weather turned. Someone, long ago, looked at the rain and decided the conversation should not have to stop. It is a small thing. It tells you what they thought the talking was worth.

5 We have been leaving. The corporate plaza now stands where the common ground used to, the privately owned public space that looks open and is not, that admits the customer and moves the rest of us along. The screen took the rest. Since the early years of this century the meeting, the argument, the slow work of showing up has migrated from the square to the feed, and the room at the center of the city has begun to empty. Attendance at the town meeting has fallen since the 1970s. The revolutions were declared in squares; the Bastille fell in a public street, and the colonists who would not be ruled gathered, of all the unremarkable places, in the town square. We are not gathering there now.

6 So the square waits. It is older than any of us and patient in a way we are not, holding its open middle for whoever comes back to stand in it. The Romans had a phrase for the thing that belongs to everyone and to no one, the *res publica*, the public thing, and they meant a ground you could not sell because it was already ours. It is still there, most of it, under the new towers and the rented benches. The door is open. We have simply stopped walking through it.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's position on the public square across the opener?
 - A) A nostalgic ideal that never truly granted the open access the writer attributes to it
 - B) A place of enduring civic worth that the public has gradually abandoned rather than lost to any single cause
 - C) A historical institution whose usefulness ended once digital platforms offered a more efficient substitute
 - D) A contested site whose value depends on which political faction controls it at a given moment
2. In the fourth paragraph, the writer dwells on the covered walkways of the Stoa primarily to
 - A) honor the care earlier citizens gave to keeping public conversation alive
 - B) prove that the agora was the largest public space of its era
 - C) establish the architectural sophistication of ancient Greek engineering
 - D) argue that modern squares should be redesigned for shelter

Discussion questions:

1. The writer chooses to consecrate the square rather than argue for it, never naming an opponent or rebutting a counterclaim. How does that consecratory stance shape what the piece can and cannot persuade a reader to do?
2. The opener ends on 'We have simply stopped walking through it' rather than on a call to act. What is gained, and what is risked, by closing a piece about civic decline without telling the reader what to do?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage consecrates the public square as the place where citizenship happens. Read it carefully. Then write a well-developed essay in which you analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to elevate the public square and to convey its loss. In your response you should establish a defensible thesis about the writer's rhetorical purpose; select and analyze specific evidence from the passage, attending to choices such as the accumulation of historical examples under a repeated frame, the contrast between belonging and buying, and the closing benediction; explain how those choices work together to create meaning; and demonstrate control of the conventions of written English. Do not summarize the passage.